

Dynamic Verbs & Scalar Change in Chechen

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A Brief Reminder of Vendler's Categories (1967)

- This study investigates two types of Aktionsarten (Achievements vs. accomplishments) as they exist for verbs of scalar change in Chechen.

(Vendler 1967)	Durative	Dynamic	Telic
State	+	-	-
Activity	+	+	-
Accomplishment	+	+	+
Achievement	-	+	+

Critique of Vendler: The Problem of Scalar Verbs

Rappaport Hovav (2008) points out that certain classes of verbs (which she dubs “Scalar Verbs), operate on a lexically encoded scale, indicating a measurable change in their specific property:

- (1) a. Inflation increased for six years straight.
 - b. Inflation increased five percent in three months.
 - c. They predict that inflation will increase in three months
- (Rappaport Hovav 2009:38)

This evidence points to a heterogeneous interpretation of the verb “to increase,” because of its association with the Scalar Change of the Degree Achievement Verb.

Overview



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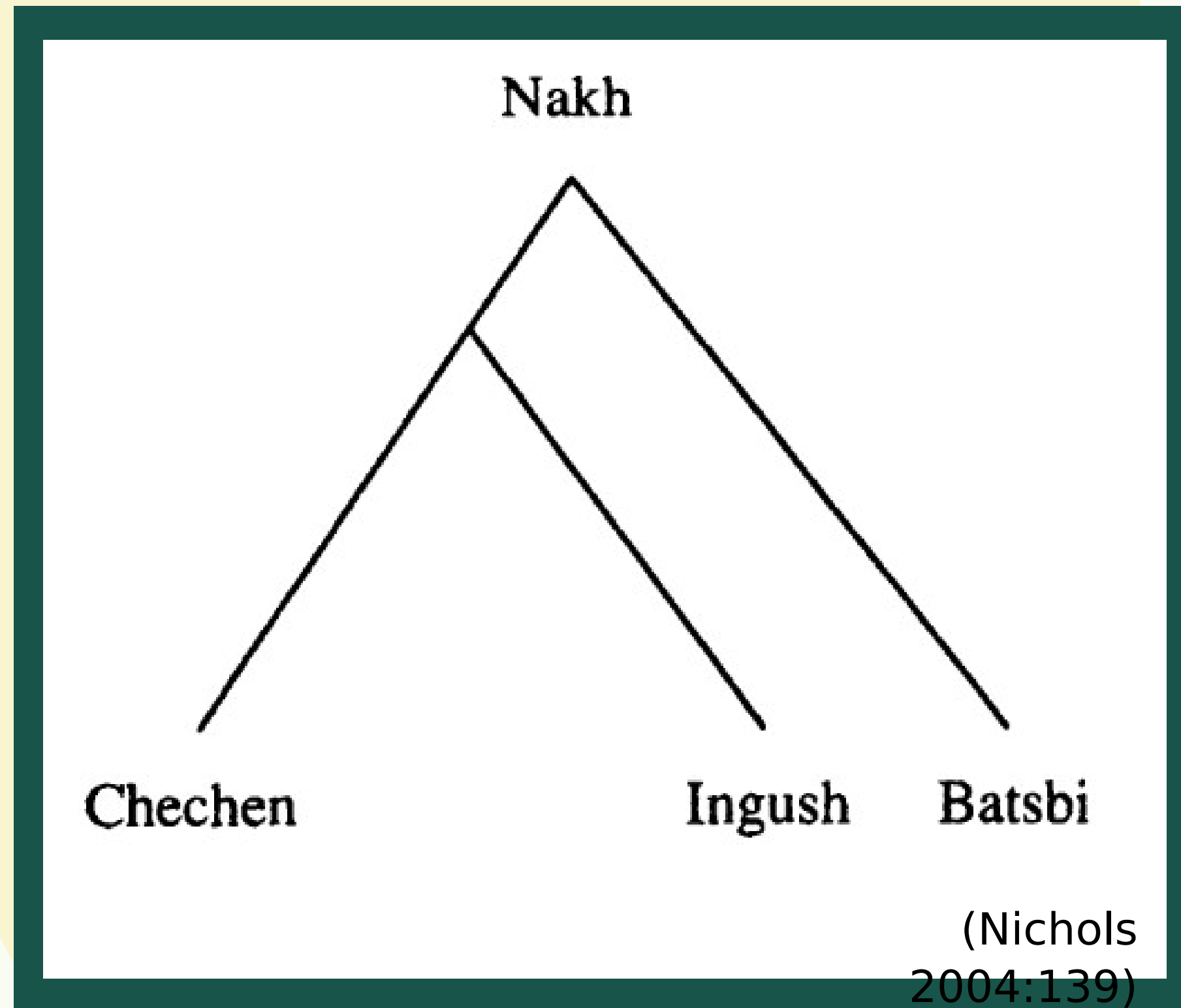
This research aims to determine whether Chechen verbs can be systematically classified according to the same lexically specified scale and whether this classification aligns with the theories developed by Rappaport-Hovav (2008) in her work on categories of aspects.



Scalar properties of verbs related to temperature in Chechen

The Noxchii

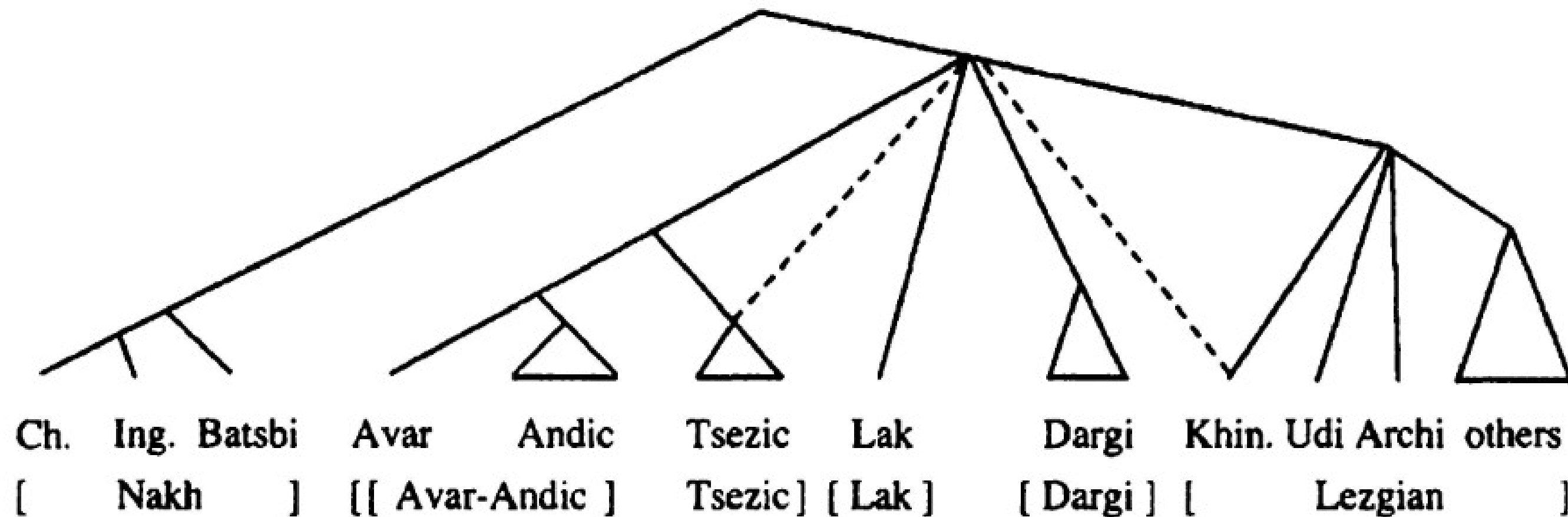
- Chechen speakers are part of the Northeast Caucasian language family.
- Speakers refer to themselves as the Noxchii, an ethnonym meaning referring to Chechen speakers of the central plain and highland mountains of the Southwestern Caucasus (Nichols 2004:131)





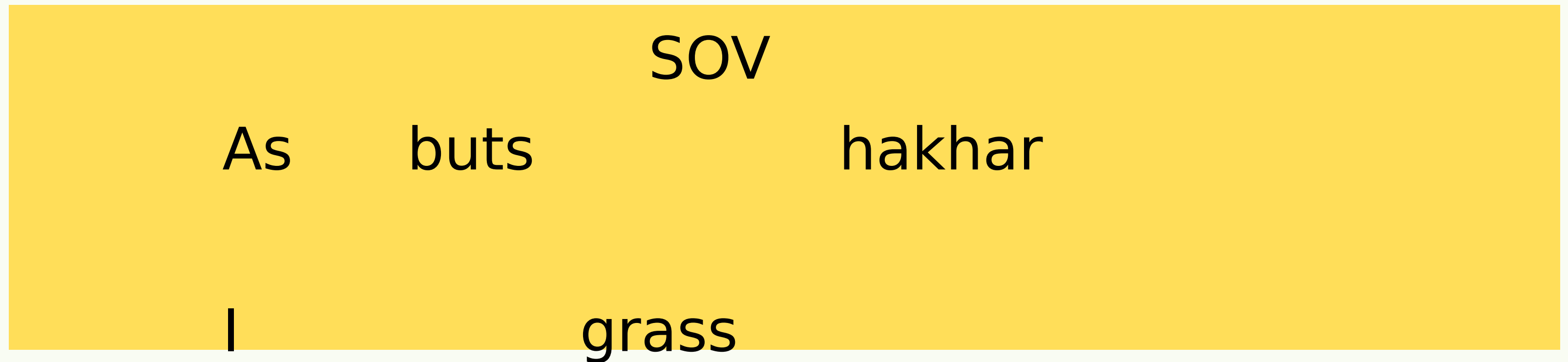
Nakh-Dagestanic or Northwest-Caucasian
Family

The Nakh-Dagestani Family



(Nichols
2004:140)

Syntax, Word Order and Basic Clause Structure



- Word order is SOV but alternation is frequent.
- Typologically it is head-final, suffixing, ergative, case-using, and dependent-marking. (Good 2003:113)
- The clause structure of Chechen involves TAM markers that are attached to the end of Verb Stems.

Methodology

Pilot Study:

- A single native speaker was asked to rate the grammaticality of 15 phrases using the scalar verbs “to cool” “to warm” and “to widen”.
- Tests were adapted from Rapaport Hovav (2008) for Chechen using original translations created by hand using the grammar of Chechen developed by Dutton and Doyle (2018) and confirmed by our native speaker.

The Participant

- 25 Year old
- Male
- Native Speaker from Grozny



(BBC
2001)

How Do Degree Achievement and Scalar Verbs Lexicalize Scale in Chechen?

In response to Zarina and Nichols' 2018 study of TAM in Chechen, this paper proposes to adapt the scalar tests developed by Rappaport-Hovav (2008) to test the degree of scalar change as verbs move toward a culminating achievement along a lexicalized scale.

The Basic Structure

Chechen is an agglutanative language and scalar verbs combine to create verbs related to scalar change involving temperature:

Della	+	<u>Mela</u>	=	<u>Melladella</u>
become.PST.3SG		Warm.ADJ		Become
warm.PST.3SG				

It became warm.

The Basic Structure with

Degrees

(5) ~~Merza~~ h'okhum Mela 100°

Pie

Warm.ADJ 100°

The pie warmed to 100°

b. Merza h'okhum Meladella

Pie

warm.become.PST.3SG

The pie warmed.

Scalar Verbs with Temperature

(2). a. Khee sheeldella

Water cool-become.PST.3SG

The water cooled.

b. *Khee sheeldella

TS1H

Sattah

Water cool-become.PST.3SG for

hour

The water cooled for an hour.

Minimalist Interpretation

(3). a. Khee sheeldella

Water cool-become.PST.3SG

The water cooled.

b. * Khee sheeldella, lakhdahar

Water cool-become.PST.3SG, down

The water cooled, down.

Modifications

(4). a. Chorpa sheeldella

Soup cold.become.PST.3SG

The soup cooled.

b. *Chorpa Derrig Sheeldella

Soup all.DET

cold.become.PST.3SG

The soup cooled completely

Scalar Verbs with Temperature

(5). c. *Merza h'okhum tsha sah't meladella

Pie

one hour

warm.become.PST.3SG

The pie warmed for an hour.

d. Merza h'okhum tsha sah't dan

Pie

one

hour

make.PST.3SG

The pie cooked for an hour.

Multiple Scales in Degree

(6) a. Tsu pinah chona Shura dokha dat1ar Yera
Achievement Verbs in Chechen
Dinah

DEM wall inside crack bigger widen every
day

vay iz taelc

before CL fix-3PL.PST

'The crack in the wall widened bigger every
single day _ before we fixed it.'

Telic]

Multi-Scale Acceptance

(6).b. Hara dinah tsah Cantimeter_Tsu Pinah Choha Shura dat1ar
dokha

Single day one centimeter this wall inside crack
widen.3SG.PROG bigger

hulash

Dara

to get.3PL.PROG

Be.PST

In one day, the crack in the wall widened bigger by a centimeter.

[+Telic]

Non-Ambiguity

6.C. Kho Dinah tsah cantimeter tsu pinah choha shura
dat1ar

Three Days one centimeter this wall inside widen-
3SG.PRES.PROG crack.

The wall widened by one centimeter for three days

Summary: English & Chechen

	<u>English</u>	<u>Chechen</u>
<u>Multi-Point Scale</u>	Cooled, warmed	-
<u>Two Point Scale</u>	-	Sheeldella, Meladella
<u>Acceptance of 2+ Scales</u>	-	+
<u>Ambiguity of Duration</u>	+	-

Analysis and Conclusion

Scalar verbs Involving
Temperature Lexicalize
on a two-point closed
scale with a maximalist
interpretation

Degree Achievement Verbs can
take on multiple scales and do
not result in an ambiguous
interpretation when multiple
scales are applied

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Thank you!

For questions, email you can
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